"IN THE BEGINNING..."

GENESIS 30

IN 5 MINUTES

When:

- According to the timeline we've been using throughout this study, Jacob's journey to Haran occurred between 1760-1730 B.C.

Characters:

- Jacob – The son of Isaac and Rebekah and twin brother of Esau.
- Laban – The brother of Rebekah who lived in Haran.
- Leah – Laban's oldest daughter. She is described as having "weak" eyes.
- Rachel – The daughter of Laban. She was a shepherdess of her father's flocks in Haran. She is described as "beautiful in form and appearance."

Where:

- The events recorded in Genesis 30 took place in Haran, the homeland of Abraham's brother Nahor.

Outline:

- RACHEL'S SERVANT CONCEIVES CHILDREN WITH JACOB (30:1-8):
    + Rachel envied her sister Leah because she was barren.
    + Rachel gave Jacob her servant Bilhah so she could bear children for Jacob.
    + Bilhah bore Jacob two sons, Dan and Naphtali.
- LEAH'S SERVANT CONCEIVES CHILDREN WITH JACOB (30:9-13):
    + After four sons, Leah was no longer bearing children, so she gave Jacob her servant Zilpah to bear children in her place.
    + Zilpah bore Jacob two sons, Gad and Asher.
- LEAH'S MANDRAKES (30:14-21):
    + Reuben, Leah's son, found mandrakes in the field and brought them to Leah.
    + Rachel wanted some of the mandrakes and struck a deal with her sister. In exchange for the mandrakes, Rachel agreed to allow Leah to sleep with Jacob that night.
    + The Lord blessed Leah and gave her two more sons, Issachar and Zebulun.
    + After bearing Jacob six sons, she gave birth to a girl who she named Dinah.
- RACHEL'S CHILDREN (30:22-24):
    + God blessed Rachel and "opened her womb."
    + She bore a son and called him Joseph.
- GOD BLESSES JACOB WITH PROSPERITY IN LABAN'S HOUSE (30:25-43):
    + Jacob wanted to return to Canaan, but Laban wanted him to stay because he knew God was blessing his house on account of Jacob.
    + Jacob agreed to continue working for Laban if Laban would give him all the speckled and spotted sheep and goats and all the black lambs of his flock.
    + Laban agreed to the terms and Jacob began his work.
    + In order to increase the number of spotted and speckled animals in his flock, Jacob placed striped sticks in front of sheep when they bred.
    + Based on my research, it appears the ancients believed the offspring of the sheep were influenced by the objects the animals were viewing at the time of breeding.
    + Jacob also used some selective breeding methods. He only placed the striped sticks in front of the animals if they were healthy and strong.
    +Using these techniques, his flock of striped, speckled, and black sheep and goats grew significantly, and Jacob became very prosperous.

Application:

- God is less interested in our techniques and more interested in our reliance on Him.
- Jacob gave God the glory for any success he had brought to Laban's house, and because of it, God continued to bless Jacob.
- Knowing what we know now about breeding and genetics, it's clear that forcing sheep/goats to stare at striped sticks doesn't increase the chances of speckled and striped offspring.
- God blessed Jacob even though his science wasn't up to date.
- Perhaps we should spend less time relying on our own ingenuity, strategy, and cleverness when it comes to multiplying God's flock (the Church), and more time in prayer and in recognition of the necessity of God's power to work through our insufficiency.